

Her lips pressed tightly in the center, curling upwards at the corners forming a happy crescent. Deep in her eyes one could see a nuance she hoped to conceal. A baby was lying on the floor, looking up with a gaping smile, the one of curious bliss that babies so often have. She pulled off a tiny purple t-shirt with cracked remnants of a graphic, and then tiny khaki shorts with a wrinkly elastic waistband. Laying the clothing down by her side, she picked up a white rag and dipped it into a small bowl of water. As she began to rub encrusted dirt off the boy's forehead, he looked up through his eyebrows to follow her hand. When the rag was dipped back into the water it formed small sandy rings that got increasingly bigger as they moved towards the edges of the bowl. She continued from the forehead, to the cheeks, to the chest, and was now rubbing down his puffy arms and legs. Off to the side she reached into a loose bag and fished out a diaper, removing the old and replacing with the new. After another look ensured the removal of all grime, the mother looped the boy's head through the hole of the tattered shirt and each leg through the frayed shorts. The baby peered into her almond eyes, which had three whiskers of wrinkles growing out of the edges.

Their house was still standing, but many of her neighbors were left with plots of ash and blackened wood. Oscillating sirens had filled the previous night, but now the morning was still. Little melodies of wind chimes floated in and birds chirped. One could almost have thought nothing was wrong, but a closer examination of the living room and kitchen would have revealed an unnatural minimalism. A cardboard tube where one expected paper towels, dull bulbs where light would previously have shown, and dust hung in the air. It felt as though life had frozen in time. The future, which previously had always been anticipated and planned so meticulously was now an uncertain haze. But life needed to be attended to and so Sarah continued. She had piled clothes into a suitcase on the floor and was just now zipping it closed as she prepared to leave. Sarah decided she would use these errands as a way to show little Jesse the world. She picked him up securing him into a carrier on her chest,

slung a bag around her shoulder, and grabbing her suitcase, went out the front door.

Walking down the sidewalk, the boy observed his surroundings casting a wide net with his big round eyes, a few moments looking ahead, to the left for a bit, and then to the right. Every now and then he would glance at his mother to see what she thought of what they were seeing. Their neighborhood was like a patchy beard, with some spots barren and others full. The couple living to the right of them, Joel and Cathleen, had their house hit with an incendiary bomb. The evening it happened, once the bombers had all flew past and everyone returned from the shelters, Sarah was entering her home with the boy and looked over to see the couple on their lawn watching the last of the flickering flames. She now was making her way past the memory of a house, observing her surroundings to see if the mental image of her neighborhood needed to be updated. The two wheels of a rolling suitcase kicked rocks up and teetered over acorns as it dragged behind her. Since the new family had moved in, Sarah hadn't built very close connections with any of her neighbors, she had been so focused on their new life as a young family. Her husband John was drafted, so now she was by herself with little Jesse, and recently she had begun to wonder if she should have invited those on her street over for dinner at least a few times. She could use the support now. About a mile down the road was a public park that she often liked to take little Jesse to. Here and there they would see large sooty holes in the ground, but the trees still grew green leaves and the bushes retained their flowers. There were a number of families scattered about, those who had lost their homes camped out in the park because the schools had been unable to maintain the incoming volume.

Once they had found a cozy spot, Sarah pulled out a blanket from her bag and rolled it out over the dewy grass. Little Jesse was anxious to explore, so she lifted him from the carrier and set him on their newly carved out section. He crawled about grasping at dandelions and wisps of tall grass. Sarah looked up and noticed a hawk cutting through the brisk

air. It seemed to be writing a message as it glided back and forth in curves and dashes. She returned her gaze to little Jesse and found him attempting to eat a rock. Quickly removing it from his tiny grip, she threw it off in the distance. Within her bag she turned over various items to reveal a cup of apple sauce buried underneath, she grabbed it along with a stainless steel spoon and began feeding little Jesse. In place of the rock she had taken, little Jesse clung onto a stick, which he beat onto his pillowy thigh in awkward bursts of arrhythmic taps. After a fifteen minutes Sarah began to pack up her possessions back into her bag. The tufts of little Jesse's blond hair fluttered in the breeze as Sarah scooped him up and they continued on their journey.

About a mile down the road was a shopping center. The mother and child made their way into a store on the edge of the strip. Upon entering Sarah was greeted by a sales clerk who maintained a reflective toothy grin from the moment she entered.

"How can I help you today?"

The clerk said with a feigned southern drawl. Her hair was dark like coffee grinds and tucked behind both of her ears, and her eyes were deep and blue like a cold ocean. She never once looked to anything other than Sarah, and her smile only ceded when she pursed her lips to swallow saliva.

"Bring it up here, yes right here."

Sarah approached the sales counter and to indicate where it was that she should put the suitcase, the clerk patted down and spread the counter as if she were removing wrinkles from a cloth. Having noticed that Sarah was struggling to lift up the suitcase with the baby strapped to her front, the clerk went around the sales counter over to Sarah.

"Please, let me get it. I'll just lift it up for you."

The blue eyed clerk smiled as she slid the case on its side onto the grey counter.

"May I open it?"

Sarah nodded.

When the clerk opened the suitcase, on top was a white bridal gown. Its sleeves and bodice had subtle little crystal embellishments and the long flowing tulle skirt was bunched up at the bottom of the case. The clerk lifted it out, and holding it with both hands at the top corners, unfurled it in front of her. Observing it she made little comments.

“Ah, yes. Beautiful. Elegant”

She laid it on a table behind the sales counter and went back to the suitcase. A purple little draw string bag had been revealed once the bridal gown was removed. It jangled as the clerk peeked into it. She began to unload its contents onto the clothes that remained in the suitcase. Gold necklaces, platinum bands, and radiant earrings poured out. As the clerk analyzed the quality, glints reflected off the liquid in Sarah’s eye, resembling the sun flickering off a calm lake.

“Yes, these are wonderful. I think we’ll be able to take a lot of this. Just beautiful.”

After inspecting the remainder of the jewelry, the clerk flipped through the remaining clothing and grabbed a few of the items.

“Ok. We’ll be able to take most of it, but I did leave a few things.”

“How much will it be?”

“Let me see.”

The clerk grabbed a printing calculator and began summing up the total. Little Jesse’s eyes wandered around at store, noticing signs he could not read, racks of clothes lined along the walls, and then he craned his neck to investigate a source of light coming from a door behind the sales counter. Sarah tilted her head down to look at little Jesse, then went back to patiently watching the sales clerk pricing up the items.

“Ok, I think I can do \$350 for all of it. Will that work?”

Sarah paused for a moment.

“Including the Jewelry?”

“Yes. I’m sorry to say it, but so much Jewelry has come in lately. You have to understand that second hand isn’t nearly as desirable.”

“Ok.”

“Is \$350 satisfactory?”

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“Yes.”

The door jangled as Sarah pushed her way out of it, and she moved deeper into the shopping center. They entered a grocery store, and she grabbed a cart and tucked little Jesse into the seat of it. Snaking her way through various aisles, Sarah inspected the hollow shelves, tucking away whatever of their favorite items she could find into the cart. Once Sarah finished collecting all she needed she made her way to the front, and little Jesse tilted his head forming wrinkles on the back of his neck as he watched the giant ceiling fans. The cart dragged its back wheels as Sarah pushed it into the checkout lane. The grocery clerk began scanning and bagging, and as he did Sarah perused the candy. She grabbed a chocolate bar and added it to the cart.

“Your total is \$95”

After handing him what she owed, Sarah started to put the bagged groceries into her suitcase.